

Q My baby looks nothing like the pictures in magazines. Why is this?

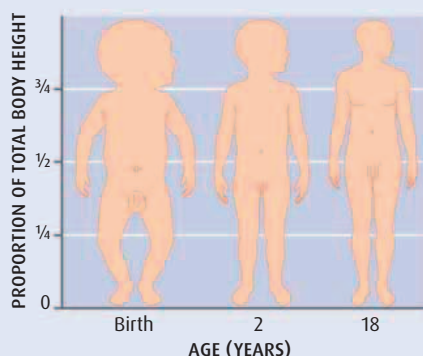
First-time parents can be surprised at the appearance of their newborn. The bundle of joy you are handed after birth may not be the picture-perfect vision you had in mind. It is good to understand why and to remember that even though each baby is unique, they all share some physical characteristics at this time.

Whether your baby has been pushed, squashed, and squeezed down the birth canal following a vaginal delivery or has been delivered by cesarean section, she has been through an enormous event. Added to this, her appearance bears testimony to the nine months she has spent curled up in your uterus, floating in the amniotic fluid. Given this, it is not surprising that she emerges

swollen, bruised, and bloody. Rest assured that many of her newborn features—a larger head in comparison to the rest of her body, swollen facial features, skin covered in a strange coating and enlarged genitals—will settle down after a day or so as she recovers from the birth. Try to enjoy her newborn looks while you can, since they won't last long!

HEAD

Your baby's head is a quarter of her body length. The skull bones are soft and flexible and have gaps between them. These "soft spots" are called the fontanelles—handle these areas gently after birth. They will disappear completely by 18 months old. During labor, the skull bones move and mold the head to help it pass through the birth canal. This can give newborns a cone-shaped head. If you had an assisted delivery, there may be bruising where the forceps were positioned or a swelling where the vacuum extractor was placed; this goes down in 24–48 hours. Your baby's head will gradually round out and any marks will disappear.



Head size As your baby grows, his body will become more in proportion with his head.

HAIR

Your baby may be virtually bald or have an impressive shock of hair. This hair is often shed in the first few months, and the new hair that replaces it may bear no resemblance to the newborn crop, but look more like the hair you would expect her to have.

SKIN

Your baby is likely to emerge covered in blood, amniotic fluid, and a creamy, waxy substance called vernix caseosa—this coated her skin in the uterus, ensuring that she didn't become waterlogged. If she is born after 41 weeks, she may have shed some of the vernix already, and her skin might be a little dry. Your baby may also have patches of fine, downy hair called lanugo. This would have kept the vernix in place.

While the skin may look purplish at first, once your baby starts to breathe on her own, her color will settle down. Her skin will also look quite fine, and you may be able to see tiny blood vessels under the surface in certain areas. Because the circulation is immature, the hands and feet may appear blue for a day or so.

EYES AND NOSE

Your baby's nose may be quite squashed after a vaginal birth, and that cute, turned up appearance enables your little one to breathe easily while feeding. Your baby's eyes may be swollen and puffy and the whites of the eye may be bloodshot from the pressure of squeezing through the birth canal.

